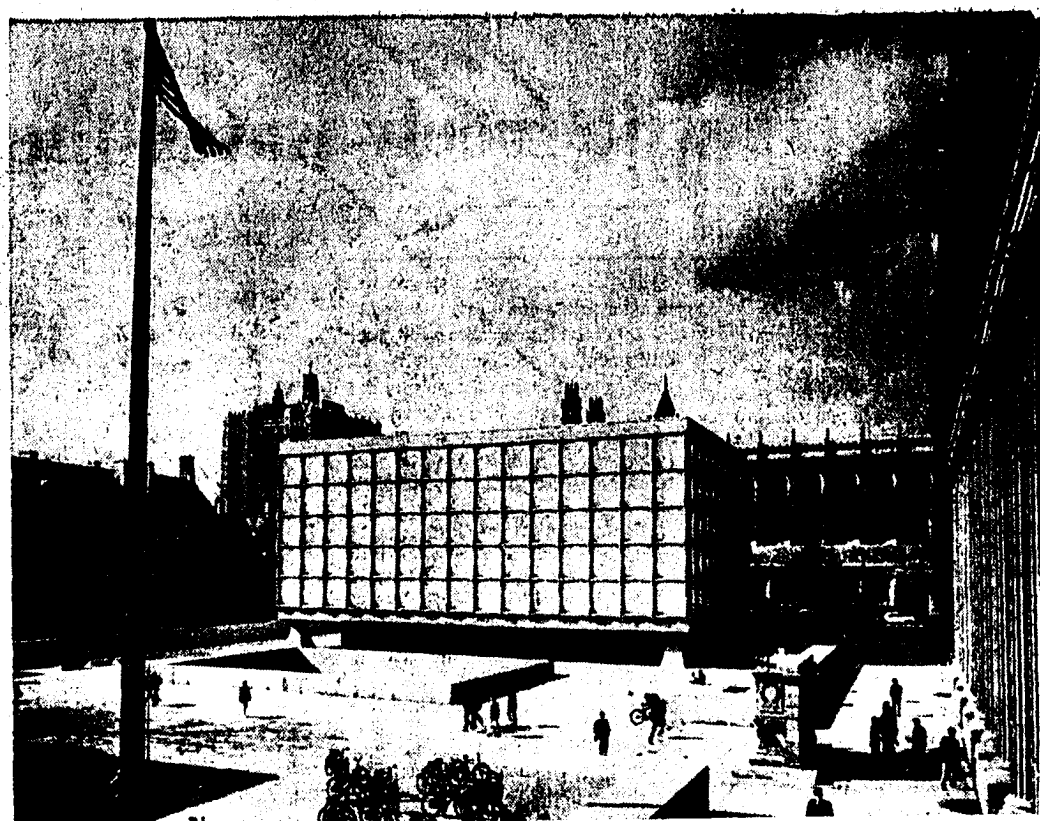




Photograph of Yale's Beinecke Rare Book and Manuscript Library is among those in the DeCordova exhibition.

A bright, flawed beginning

The exhibition called "New Architecture in New England," which opened last Sunday at the De Cordova Museum, is a rare and holy event on the local scene, the only museum show on its subject ever held here.

It tackles its topic head-on by setting out to choose the 52 best buildings done in New England in the last 10 years and display them in murals and slides. They range from the obvious musts, like Boston City Hall by Kallmann McKinnell & Knowles, and the Exeter School Library by Louis Kahn, all the way down to the inevitably personal and quirky selections that must round out any such list.

Aimed at the general public rather than architecture specialists, the show should succeed in what it sets out to do, which is to develop a broader public interest and appreciation of contemporary design, a field in which New England has more than its share of masterpieces.

At the same time, and just as interesting as the buildings themselves, is the intriguing glimpse the

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show provides into what one museum and its curator think architecture is. The De Cordova definition is clear, and while I don't altogether agree with it, I'm glad it raises so many relevant questions.

Buildings, the show implies by the way it chooses and displays them, can be thought of as works of art very much like sculptures. They are mostly for looking at. Their outsides are more important than their insides. Their physical surroundings don't matter much, their social context less. And if they're really good, they're probably big, heavy at the top and made of concrete.

As one visitor pointed out, all the buildings in the show look as if they belong in the same place, but there is no indication as to why that place happens to be New England.

Maybe some of this is unfair, since a part of the exhibition devoted to color slides of interiors, history and texture wasn't in place

for the opening. Still, a tipoff to the museum's attitudes, which perhaps reflect most people's, is in the 52 large, black-and-white mural photographs, one of each building, which form the backbone of the show. No fewer than 49 show the outside of the building rather than the inside; of the three exceptions, two are shopping malls, a building type that virtually has no outside. Even in the case of the Brown University swimming pool, an exterior photo is used — even though the photo doesn't give the slightest hint as to why this seemingly very awkward building should have been included in the show.

And with few exceptions, the photographs are cropped in a way that excludes their relationship to anything around them. The camera frames only the building, like a painting.

The rest of the exhibit is a slide-show covering all 52 buildings it does a lot better, using three screens simultaneously to give some sense of space and context. But still the camera rarely ventures into interiors, and complex social and economic truths are papered over with such statements as the one that the Christian Science Center was "built on 15 acres of what had been a blighted area." Blighted from whose point of view?

And despite the show's commendable effort to reach the layman, statements like "verticals are victory, horizontals are defeat" in the taped narration don't add an awful lot of depth to anyone's perceptions.

Finally, the choice of building types is somewhat dated. All the emphasis is on the big monuments, the peacocks of the architectural world. Few buildings are here because they suggest a way to do a particular job modestly and well, although the need to develop that kind of vernacular design is critical. Left out are such everyday 20th century types as apartment buildings, stores, parking garages, office towers. No building here is made of wood. And no attention is paid to the field of creative recycling of older buildings, one of the bright spots of contemporary design.

In a way inevitably, the show is an exhibit of photographs rather than buildings, and the photographs have their own aesthetic range, which runs from wonderful to awful. Two or three murals by Ezra Stoller (Yale's Beinecke Library, placed marvellously in space, with a spidery foreground of black bicycles, or the Boston Five Cents Savings Bank) are small masterpieces in their own right, while a blessedly anonymous depiction of Le Corbusier's Carpenter Center at Harvard somehow makes that uniquely active building look dowdy, shapeless and dull.

Despite the drawbacks, which are perhaps the inevitable result of art-oriented people courageously and commendably venturing into unfamiliar waters, this is a show of real merit and importance. If architecture is to grow and flourish, it needs an appreciative audience. It needs laymen who want to be architecture fans, buffs, informed connoisseurs like those of painting and baseball and auteurist cinema.

But the rules in architecture are different. Buildings don't have frames around them, either in time or in space, and they live or die, even in the narrow visual sense, only by their success as part of something larger than themselves — landscapes or townscapes.

Hopefully, the De Cordova has started a dialogue that other museums will join. The show continues through Jan. 15.